

Pre-Internet Old Dudes

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Executive Summary

Modern online gurus all converge on the same "build a personal brand, post more" advice. The speaker argues the truly trustworthy mentors are pre-internet business builders who had no safety net of social media and had to be ruthlessly resourceful.

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The "Post More" Guru Problem 0:00

- Every online guru, expert, and influencer today gives identical advice regardless of context
 - "Build a personal brand"
 - "Grow your audience"
 - "Post more" — parodied as needing to "post 7 trillion times an hour"
 - "Get a million followers and you'll be fine"
- The speaker's core critique: this advice is hollow because these gurus have infrastructure behind them
 - "Yeah, but you have a team of 50 people doing it for you"
- The sameness is the tell — if everyone arrives at the exact same conclusion, it stops being insight and becomes noise

Why Pre-Internet Old Dudes Are More Trustworthy 0:48

- The speaker's alternative: research the builders from before the internet era
 - Conrad Hilton — built Hilton Hotels
 - Isadore Sharp — founded Four Seasons
 - Howard Schultz — built Starbucks
 - Jack Cohen / the Tesco founder
 - **Sam Walton** — built Walmart
- The reasoning: pre-internet brand-building was orders of magnitude harder

- No social media reach, no viral loops, no algorithm to distribute content
- Getting customers required genuine ingenuity and physical effort
- "Could you imagine how hard it was pre-internet era to build a brand and a following?"
- Because the environment was so unforgiving, the tactics these men used had to actually work — they couldn't fake results with vanity metrics

Sam Walton as the Prime Example 1:11

- Walton's site-selection method: flew planes over the United States scanning for gaps
 - He would spot clusters of houses with no supermarket between them
 - "There's no supermarket in between. We need a location there."
 - This was a purely physical, boots-on-the-ground competitive intelligence process
- Walton's competitive research method: entered rival stores with a tape measure
 - Measured the distance between every aisle in a competitor's store
 - Goal: determine whether his own store could offer a better customer experience through more physical space and easier movement
- The speaker's reaction: "That is just the hardest level of business possible. That is business on steroids."

"When you hear stuff like that, you're like, 'God, that is just the hardest level of business possible. That is business on steroids.'"

What Real Business Building Looked Like 2:20

- Contrast with modern content-business shortcuts
 - Example given: post a video → 3 people buy a product → make 10K in a day → make a video about making 10K → earn another 100 → repeat
 - "It's almost too easy to everybody to replicate" — the feedback loop is self-referential and inflated
- Pre-internet builders had none of today's shortcuts
 - No personal brand — "nobody knew who they were"
 - Had to physically meet people, shake hands, negotiate leases on premises
 - Had to stock a location with inventory
 - Then had to figure out how to market that to the world with no digital distribution
- This is what earns the speaker's trust: the complexity and resourcefulness required was real, verifiable, and couldn't be gamed